

GuestIQ Gap Analysis: Latent Guest-Expectation Dimensions Your Instrument Is Missing

TL;DR

- GuestIQ already covers the transactional and decision-funnel basics well, but the literature points to roughly a dozen **latent, emotional, sensory, and behavioral-economic constructs** — sleep architecture, multisensory servicescape, decision regret/choice overload, price-fairness (vs. price), feeling-at-home/belonging, the peak-end memory structure, and inclusion/identity dimensions — that are absent from your map and invisible to PMS/RMS/reputation tools.
- The highest-"wow," most defensible additions are: a **peak-end / "trough" memory module**, a **multisensory + sleep-environment module**, a **decision-regret and choice-overload module** (pre-booking psychology no tool captures), a **price-fairness-vs-price module**, and an **inclusion/safety projection module** (solo-female, neurodivergent, LGBTQ+, dietary/religious) — all capturable through front-desk projection.
- Frame the instrument's unique value on validated theory: front-desk staff are documented to hold customer-value knowledge that diverges from both managers' and guests' self-reports, making them a legitimate expert proxy for the *stated-vs-revealed* "say-do" gap that surveys miss.

Key Findings

1. Your current instrument is strong on the funnel and the transaction, thin on emotion, memory, sensory, and decision-psychology. GuestIQ thoroughly maps trip intent, the consideration set, room non-negotiables, service style, value framework, and departure. What is largely missing is the *experiential and psychological superstructure* that academic hospitality research treats as the real driver of loyalty and word-of-mouth: how the stay is *remembered*, how it *feels* across the senses, how the booking *decision* is psychologically constructed, and how *fairness, belonging, and identity* are experienced.

2. The single biggest structural gap is memory architecture — the peak-end rule. Kahneman's peak-end rule, validated in tourism (Kim, 2019, *Journal of Heritage Tourism*; Lin, 2025, *Cornell Hospitality Quarterly*), holds that retrospective evaluation is driven disproportionately by the most intense moment (peak) and the final moment (end), not the average. Your "exceptional lever" captures the peak partially, but you do not capture the **"trough"** (the single worst moment that anchors a memory) or the **end** as a distinct, designable construct separate from checkout logistics. This is decision-ready and unique: reputation tools capture the post-hoc rating but never decompose *which moment* created it. (ResearchGate)

3. Sleep and multisensory environment are under-instrumented despite being primary satisfaction drivers. Mao, Yang & Wang (2018, *IJHM*) and Robbins et al. (2021, *Tourism & Hospitality Research*, N=609, 26 attributes examined; Harvard/Brigham & Women's) found sleep was inversely associated with "uncomfortable bed linen," "uncomfortable pillows," and "sound from the air conditioning unit or heater" — and that only one in three travelers report being satisfied with sleep on the road, with sleep satisfaction a strong predictor of overall hotel satisfaction. Bitner's (1992, *Journal of Marketing*) servicescape and the "scentscape" extension treat ambient conditions (scent, soundscape, lighting/circadian, thermal) as behavior-shaping. Your instrument captures noise and cleanliness but not the integrated *sleep-environment* and *multisensory* constructs. (Sage Journals) (National Geographic)

4. Pre-booking decision psychology — choice overload and anticipated regret — is a blind spot no tool can see. Park & Jang (2013, *Tourism Management*) demonstrated choice overload in travel; Guillet, Mattila & Gao (2020, *IJHM*) showed large OTA choice sets plus price complexity create "consumer confusion" that drives booking deferral/abandonment. Masiero, Yang & Qiu (2019, *Tourism Management* 73:83–93), analyzing stated preferences of 719 Hong Kong tourists, found "the random regret minimization model performs significantly better than the random utility maximization model" — i.e., guests **minimize anticipated regret rather than maximize utility** when choosing on location. Jo et al. (2022, *Journal of Travel Research*) tied OTA affordances to impulsive booking and **post-purchase regret**. Your "abandonment triggers" touches this; the *psychology* (overload, regret-minimization, post-booking dissonance) is unexploited. (ScienceDirect + 2)

5. Price *fairness* is a distinct construct from price/value — and a "wow" because RMS optimizes the very thing that erodes it. El Haddad et al. (2015, *Journal of Vacation Marketing*) show price-fairness perception directly drives behavioral intention; dynamic-pricing studies on Booking.com found rate variation across room types and stay-weeks reduces perceived fairness. This is strategically explosive: IDEaS/Duetto maximize revenue via the dynamic pricing that the fairness literature says corrodes trust. A front-desk-projected fairness module reveals the hidden cost of the RMS.

6. "Feeling at home," belonging, and hospitableness are validated emotional constructs central to differentiation. Research conceptualizes "home feeling" as a multidimensional PASS_h process (physical/spatial, social, affective, plus hospitality) and "hospitableness" (Tasci & Semrad, 2016) as producing guests "feeling welcomed, wanted, cared for, safe, and important." This is the emotional layer that sharing-economy competitors weaponize and that your instrument names only obliquely via "feeling-different-from-everyday."

7. Inclusion, safety, and identity dimensions are both a moral and commercial gap — and highly projectable from the front desk. Solo-female safety (68% of solo female travelers name personal safety as a top concern, tied with higher costs at 68%, per the 2026 Solo Female Travel Trends Survey by Solo Female Travelers; Booking.com's 2024 report found 41% have changed accommodations mid-trip due to safety concerns — driven by room location, lighting, late-night staffing), neurodivergent needs (the Hyatt/KultureCity 2024 survey of 1,020 respondents, with NYU's Tisch Center, found "nearly 70 percent of caregivers and more than half of neurodivergent travelers said they would disclose their neurodiversity during the booking process for a hotel to better serve them," rising to "more than 75 percent" for neurodivergent business travelers; KultureCity notes "one in every four individuals in the U.S. has a sensory need or an invisible disability"), LGBTQ+ comfort, and dietary/cultural/religious accommodation are all dimensions front-desk staff observe constantly but that no PMS field or post-stay survey systematically captures. (Food Drink Life + 4)

8. Customer *delight* (vs. satisfaction) and the experience-economy realms give you a validated vocabulary for the "exceptional lever." Oliver, Rust & Varki's delight construct (high pleasure + high arousal triggered by surprise) and Pine & Gilmore's 4Es (entertainment, education, escapism, esthetics) are both validated in lodging. Your "exceptional lever" is intuitively this but un-theorized; adopting the delight/surprise and 4E framing makes the output credible to a sophisticated GM. (Academia.edu)

9. Biophilic design, status/identity signaling, autonomy/control, and effort/friction round out the missing behavioral set. A biophilic-lobby study (2023, *IJHM*) found natural elements raise pleasure, lower arousal, and increase willingness to pay via "peace of mind." Self-congruity research (Ekinci et al., *IJHM*; Sop & Kozak, 2019) shows guests choose and stay loyal to brands matching self-image. SST-autonomy studies (Kim & Qu, *Journal of Business Research*) show guests have distinct desires for autonomy and control; the Customer Effort Score (Dixon et al., 2010, *HBR*) shows reducing effort predicts loyalty better than delight. (ScienceDirect + 2)

Details: Missing Constructs, Sources, Why They Matter, and Sample Front-Desk-Projected Items

For each construct below I give: the academic/industry source, why it matters for guest expectations, and a draft survey item answerable by an experienced front-desk professional role-playing a chosen archetype.

A. Memory & Evaluation Architecture

A1. Peak-End Rule & the "Trough." Source: Kahneman (peak-end rule); Kim (2019, *Journal of*

Heritage Tourism); Lin (2025, *Cornell Hospitality Quarterly*, "Peak-End Rule? Tracing Tourists' Experience"). *Why*: Retrospective evaluation and revisit/WOM are driven by the peak, the trough, and the end — not the average. *Items*: "Thinking as [archetype], what single moment during the stay would become the emotional 'peak' they tell others about?" / "What is the one moment most likely to become the 'low point' that anchors a bad memory even if everything else was fine?" / "Independent of checkout logistics, what would make the *final* impression — the last 15 minutes — memorable for the right reasons?" (ResearchGate)

A2. Customer Delight vs. Satisfaction (surprise/arousal). *Source*: Oliver, Rust & Varki (1997); Torres & Kline; Kim, Vogt & Knutson (2015, *Journal of Hospitality & Tourism Research*). *Why*: Delight (joy + surprise + high arousal) predicts loyalty and WOM more strongly than mere satisfaction and is distinct from meeting expectations. *Item*: "As [archetype], what *unexpected* gesture (not on any amenity list) would produce genuine surprise and delight — and what's the risk it 'raises the bar' for next time?" (Academia.edu)

A3. Memorable Tourism Experience dimensions. *Source*: Kim, Ritchie & McCormick (2012, *Journal of Travel Research*) — seven dimensions: hedonism, novelty, refreshment, meaningfulness, involvement, knowledge, local culture. *Why*: These predict behavioral intention better than satisfaction/quality alone. *Item*: "Which of these does this guest most want from the stay — refreshment/rejuvenation, novelty, a sense of meaning, local-culture connection — and which does our hotel actually deliver?"

B. Sensory, Sleep & Physical Environment

B1. Sleep Environment / Sleep Architecture. *Source*: Mao, Yang & Wang (2018, *IJHM*); Robbins et al. (2021, *Tourism & Hospitality Research*). *Why*: Sleep is the core product yet under-measured; specific modifiable attributes (HVAC noise, pillow/linen comfort, light control) predict overall satisfaction. *Item*: "As [archetype], rank what would most disrupt their sleep here — HVAC noise, corridor/neighbor noise, light leakage, pillow/mattress, temperature control — and which we underestimate."

B2. Multisensory Servicescape (scent, soundscape, lighting mood, thermal). *Source*: Bitner (1992, *Journal of Marketing*) servicescape; the "scentscape" framework (Roschk et al. meta-analysis of music/scent/color). *Why*: Ambient conditions shape approach/avoidance and emotion below conscious awareness; guests rarely self-report them but feel them. *Item*: "What does the hotel *smell* and *sound* like on entering, from this guest's nose and ears — and is that an asset or a liability they'd never put in a review?"

B3. Biophilic Design / Restorative Nature. *Source:* biophilic-lobby study (2023, *IJHM*); Nanu et al. (2020, *IJHM*). *Why:* Natural elements increase pleasure, lower arousal, raise willingness to pay via "peace of mind." *Item:* "Would this guest feel more restored by views, daylight, plants, or natural materials — and do they notice their absence?" (ScienceDirect)

C. Pre-Booking Decision Psychology (invisible to all existing tools)

C1. Choice Overload / Consumer Confusion. *Source:* Park & Jang (2013, *Tourism Management*); Guillet, Mattila & Gao (2020, *IJHM*). *Why:* Too many OTA options + price complexity cause confusion → deferral/abandonment. *Item:* "When this guest was comparing options, what made the decision *overwhelming*, and what one piece of clarity would have made them book us faster?" (ResearchGate)

C2. Anticipated Regret / Regret Minimization. *Source:* Masiero, Yang & Qiu (2019, *Tourism Management* 73:83–93). *Why:* Guests often choose to *minimize the chance of regret* rather than maximize utility. *Item:* "What is this guest most afraid of *regretting* about choosing us (location, safety, noise, a better deal missed) — what's the dominant anxiety?" (Polyu)

C3. Post-Purchase Dissonance / Booking Remorse. *Source:* Festinger (1957); Jo et al. (2022, *Journal of Travel Research*). *Why:* Between booking and arrival, doubt builds; pre-arrival communication can resolve or worsen it. *Item:* "In the gap between booking and arrival, what doubt creeps in for this guest — and what message from us would dissolve it?"

C4. Anticipation / Savoring (pre-experience). *Source:* Nawijn (pre-travel anticipation as catalyst of happiness); Kumar et al. (Cornell, experiential anticipation). *Why:* Anticipation is itself a source of value; hotels can extend the experience backward in time. *Item:* "What could we do *before arrival* to let this guest start enjoying the trip early — and do we currently add to or kill that anticipation?" (ScienceDirect)

D. Value, Fairness & Trust

D1. Price Fairness (distinct from price/value). *Source:* El Haddad et al. (2015, *Journal of Vacation Marketing*); Booking.com dynamic-pricing fairness studies. *Why:* Perceived *unfairness* (rate variation, surprise fees, loyalty members paying more) erodes trust and rebooking independent of absolute price — and is created by the RMS itself. *Item:* "What pricing or fee experience would make this guest feel *cheated* even if the total was acceptable — and where is our revenue strategy quietly creating that feeling?"

D2. Perceived Risk & Trust in Booking. *Source:* online-booking trust/perceived-risk literature (e.g., Tandfonline 2024 booking-intention study). *Why:* Inability to physically inspect the

product makes trust signals decisive pre-booking. *Item*: "What unspoken *risk* is this guest carrying when booking sight-unseen, and what proof would reassure them?"

E. Emotional & Identity Layer

E1. Feeling at Home / Belonging. *Source*: "home feeling" PASS_h framework (2018, *IJHM*). *Why*: The emotional driver sharing-economy rivals exploit; settling-in vs. just staying drives loyalty. *Item*: "What would make this guest *settle in* and feel they belong rather than just occupy a room?"

E2. Hospitableness. *Source*: Tasci & Semrad (2016). *Why*: Feeling "welcomed, wanted, cared for, safe, important" is the differentiating emotional core of hospitality. *Item*: "Where in our service does this guest feel genuinely *cared for* vs. merely *processed*?"

E3. Status / Identity Signaling & Self-Congruity. *Source*: Ekinici et al. (*IJHM*); Sop & Kozak (2019, *Journal of Hospitality Marketing & Management*); Han, Nunes & Drèze (2010, *Journal of Marketing*). *Why*: Guests choose and stay loyal to hotels that match/signal their self-image. *Item*: "What does staying here say *about* this guest to themselves and others — and does our brand reinforce or undercut that identity?" [Taylor & Francis Online](#)

E4. Autonomy / Perceived Control. *Source*: Kim & Qu (*Journal of Business Research*, resort SST adoption). *Why*: Guests have distinct desires for autonomy and control over the service process. *Item*: "Where does this guest want *control* (choose room, self-serve, set their own pace) vs. want to be *taken care of*?" [ScienceDirect](#)

E5. Effort / Friction (Customer Effort Score). *Source*: Dixon, Freeman & Toman (2010, *HBR*). *Why*: Reducing effort predicts loyalty more than delight; friction is felt but rarely self-reported. *Item*: "What is the single most *effortful* or annoying friction point in this guest's journey that they'd never bother to complain about but quietly resent?" [IBM](#)

F. Inclusion, Safety & Accommodation (high projectability, zero coverage in other tools)

F1. Solo-Female Safety. *Source*: 2026 Solo Female Travel Trends Survey (Solo Female Travelers); Booking.com 2024 report; hotelier practice (room location, lighting, not announcing room numbers, late-night staffing). *Why*: 68% of solo female travelers name personal safety as a top concern (tied with higher costs at 68%), and 41% have changed accommodations mid-trip due to safety concerns; design and protocol signals matter pre-arrival. *Item*: "As a solo female guest, what would make her feel *safe* here — and what current practice (room placement, check-in audibility, escort offers) silently undermines that?" [Food Drink Life](#) [Belleontheboardwalk](#)

F2. Neurodiversity / Sensory Inclusion. *Source:* Hyatt/KultureCity 2024 survey (1,020 respondents, with NYU Tisch Center); neuroinclusive-design literature. *Why:* "One in every four individuals in the U.S. has a sensory need or an invisible disability" (KultureCity); more than 50% of neurodivergent travelers and nearly 70% of caregivers would self-disclose at booking for better care. *Item:* "For a neurodivergent guest or parent of one, what sensory or predictability features (quiet room, dimmable light, visual layout, low-stimulus check-in) would matter — and what overwhelms them here?" Hotel Management Travel Weekly

F3. LGBTQ+ Inclusivity & Dietary/Cultural/Religious Accommodation. *Why:* Belonging and safety signals; dietary/religious needs (halal, kosher, allergen, prayer orientation) are observed at the desk but uncaptured. *Item:* "What inclusion or accommodation signal would make this guest feel they genuinely *belong* and are anticipated, not tolerated?"

G. Sustainability / ESG

G1. Sustainability Expectation & the Say-Do Gap. *Source:* Kang et al. (2012, *IJHM*); Bonzom et al. 2023 systematic review (*MDPI Sustainability* 15(11):8775, 22 studies/13 countries); PwC May 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey (20,000+ consumers, 31 countries). *Why:* Consumers "willing to pay" would accept a premium of around 5% for a certified green hotel (premiums of USD 1.6–9 per person per night, or USD 1.55–26 per room/night), and PwC found willingness to spend an average of 9.7% more on sustainably produced products — yet the attitude-behavior gap is large, so front desk sees the real behavior. *Item:* "Does this guest *expect* sustainability as a baseline, *pay* for it, or merely say they care — and where's the gap between stated and revealed?"

MDPI + 2

H. Technology Expectations & Digital Detox

H1. Tech Expectation vs. App Fatigue / Human-Touch Tradeoff. *Source:* Hotel Tech Report Guest Technology Report 2025; AI-concierge/contactless literature. *Why:* Guests want frictionless tech for simple tasks but human contact for complex/emotional ones; app fatigue is real (the 2025 report found 70% of guests find chatbots helpful for simple inquiries but prefer human interaction for complex requests, while 65% want hotel tech more advanced than their home tech). *Item:* "Where does this guest want *contactless/AI* speed vs. a *human* — and where would forcing an app annoy them?"

H2. Digital Detox / Disconnection. *Source:* Gen Z bleisure/disconnection trend research. *Why:* Some segments (notably leisure Gen Z) actively want to disconnect. *Item:* "Does this guest want to *disconnect* here — and do we enable or sabotage that?"

I. The Expert-Proxy Foundation (methodological "wow")

I1. Frontline Knowledge & the Perception Gap. *Source:* hospitality study finding significant disparities in customer-value perception among managers, frontline employees, and customers in 3-4 star hotels (managers' and frontline staff's views diverge, and both diverge from guests; notably, no significant gaps in 5-star hotels); Axonify 2026 frontline report on the leadership-optimism gap; Parasuraman/Zeithaml/Berry Gaps Model (the "knowledge gap," Gap 1). *Why:* This is the scientific justification for GuestIQ's entire premise — front-desk staff hold valid customer knowledge that management systematically lacks, and the "knowledge gap" (Gap 1) is exactly what the instrument surfaces. *Use:* Open the management report by framing GuestIQ as a structured instrument for closing the Gap-1 knowledge gap using the proxy with the richest observational dataset.

I2. Stated vs. Revealed Preference / Say-Do Gap. *Source:* Samuelson revealed preference; hotel stated-choice/discrete-choice literature (Verma, Plaschka & Louviere, 2002); say-do gap research. *Why:* Self-report surveys (including reputation tools) capture stated preference; front-desk staff observe revealed behavior. Position GuestIQ items to explicitly ask the proxy to flag where guests say one thing but *do* another. *Item template:* append to high-value items: "Where does this guest's stated priority diverge from what actually drives their booking and loyalty?"

Recommendations

Stage 1 — Add the four highest-"wow," highest-defensibility modules now (capturable, absent elsewhere, theory-backed):

1. **Peak-End/Trough memory module (A1)** — decompose the remembered stay into peak, trough, and end.
2. **Sleep + multisensory environment module (B1, B2)** — the core product, under-instrumented.
3. **Decision-psychology module (C1-C3: choice overload, anticipated regret, post-booking dissonance)** — pure pre-arrival psychology invisible to PMS/RMS/reputation tools.
4. **Price-fairness-vs-price module (D1)** — strategically explosive because it exposes the hidden cost of the RMS.

Stage 2 — Add the emotional/identity and inclusion layers (E1-E5 belonging/hospitableness/identity/autonomy/effort; F1-F3 inclusion/safety) once Stage 1 validates. These create the strongest differentiation vs. sharing-economy competitors and the strongest moral/commercial narrative.

Stage 3 — Add sustainability say-do, technology/digital-detox, anticipation/savoring, biophilia (G, H, C4, B3) as segment-specific add-ons.

Cross-cutting — Re-architect the instrument around two validated meta-frames: (a) the **Gaps Model / frontline-knowledge** justification (I1) as the report's framing, and (b) an explicit **stated-vs-revealed "say-do" flag** (I2) appended to every high-value item — this is the feature that makes the output unique and un-replicable by any survey tool.

Benchmarks that would change the staging: If front-desk pilot respondents cannot reliably project a construct (low inter-rater agreement across staff role-playing the same archetype), demote it from Stage 1. If a GM pilot rates a module as "already visible in my reputation/PMS data," cut it. Prioritize modules where (a) inter-rater projection is consistent AND (b) GMs rate the insight as novel and actionable.

Caveats

- Several constructs are validated as *guest-self-report* scales (LODGSERV, MTE, delight, self-congruity); their validity when answered by a **front-desk proxy** is untested and should be piloted for inter-rater reliability before claiming rigor.
- The willingness-to-pay-for-sustainability literature is genuinely mixed (the 2023 MDPI systematic review converges on ~5%, while older *IJHM* work reports a range up to ~20% depending on segment and method), and the attitude-behavior gap is large — treat any sustainability "expectation" finding as stated, not revealed.
- The Customer Effort Score originates in cross-industry practitioner/HBR work, not peer-reviewed hospitality research; pair it with the SST-autonomy academic studies for grounding.
- Some sourcing (biophilic-lobby *IJHM* 2023 authorship, exact DOIs/pages) was retrieved from reference snippets behind paywalls and should be verified before formal citation.
- Front-desk projection is strongest for *observable* behavior (revealed preference, friction, safety signals) and weakest for *internal* states the staff cannot see (private anticipation, identity meaning); calibrate confidence accordingly.
- AI-concierge adoption/satisfaction statistics circulating in trade press are largely vendor-sourced and should not be treated as independent evidence.